

# Dr. Rajiv Bahl

Secretary, Department of Health Research & Director General, Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR)

**Public-records due-diligence report:** legal cases, allegations, scams and controversies (open and closed) that name or directly involve him

| Item             | Detail                                                                                                                                                  |
|------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Date compiled    | 01 October 2026                                                                                                                                         |
| Period covered   | Full career, 1984-2026: medical training, AIIMS/ICMR (1994-2002), WHO Geneva (2003-2022), DG-ICMR (Oct 2022 onward), plus personal/non-official matters |
| Sources          | Indian Kanoon (Supreme Court, High Courts, CAT, NGT orders); Google News index; WebSearch; primary news articles; ICMR/government pages; Wikipedia      |
| Records reviewed | ~25 court/tribunal orders naming Dr. Bahl; 50+ news and web searches in English and Hindi; ~20 primary articles                                         |
| Nature of report | Compilation of public records with citations. Not legal advice. Allegations are reported as allegations, not as findings.                               |

## Bottom line

**1. No criminal case, FIR, chargesheet, CBI/ED/Vigilance probe, Lokpal/CVC complaint, or corruption/fraud/scam allegation against Dr. Rajiv Bahl personally was found** in any searched court database or news source.

**2. He is named in 22 court and tribunal orders/matters, all in his official capacity** (as DG, ICMR / Secretary, DHR). Almost all are *contempt petitions* by ICMR employees or ex-employees alleging non-compliance with service-law orders (pay, regularisation, pension, contract re-engagement). This is routine: the head of a government body is usually named as respondent or 'alleged contemnor'. **Every one of these contempt petitions found was closed, withdrawn, dropped or not pressed. No tribunal or court held him or ICMR guilty of contempt.**

**3. One adverse ruling on an administrative action under his authority:** CAT Bangalore (30.10.2025) quashed four suspension-extension orders against an ICMR scientist, including one issued by the DG-ICMR as Disciplinary Authority, as procedurally invalid (Section 4.1). It does not allege personal misconduct.

**4. Main public controversy:** in May 2024 he signed ICMR's letter disowning a BHU study on Covaxin side effects and warning of 'legal and administrative action'. Critics saw this as pressure on vaccine-safety research. The journal retracted the paper in Sept 2024. A separate Rs 5 crore defamation suit was filed by Bharat Biotech, not by Dr. Bahl or ICMR (Section 6.1).

**5. Official-capacity involvement** (not allegations; listed for completeness at your request): NGT cancer-chemicals case (he appeared personally), a Delhi HC rare-disease committee, a Supreme Court stem-cell judgment he moved to enforce, and a vaccine-injury group's letter tied to a Bombay HC filing (Section 5). A further Supreme Court contempt notice (Sept 2025) was issued to the *office* of DG-ICMR in the Bhopal gas victims' medical-care case (Section 4.3).

**6. Full career and personal matters (1984-2026):** no allegation, case, complaint or scandal was found from his AIIMS years (1994-2002) or WHO years (2003-2022). That covers WHO staff-tribunal judgments, oversight, conflict-of-interest and research-ethics checks. **No land scam, property fraud, financial fraud, FIR or company-related matter can be tied to him.** Private court cases involving other men named Rajiv Bahl were checked: two are ruled out or almost certainly different people, one is undetermined, and none is attributed to him (Sections 8-9).

## 1. Subject profile

| Field             | Detail                                                                                                                                             | Source   |
|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| Name              | Dr. Rajiv Bahl                                                                                                                                     | [36, 37] |
| Current posts     | Secretary, Department of Health Research (Ministry of Health & Family Welfare) and Director General, ICMR, since 7 Oct 2022                        | [36]     |
| Appointment       | Appointment order dated 23 Sept 2022, 3-year term, approved by Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC)                                         | [33, 34] |
| Extension         | ACC extended tenure by 2 years: 7 Oct 2025 to 6 Oct 2027                                                                                           | [35]     |
| Previous role     | Head of Research on Maternal, Newborn, Child & Adolescent Health, World Health Organization (WHO), Geneva, 2013-22                                 | [36, 37] |
| Training          | Paediatrician (MBBS, UCMS; MD Paediatrics, University of Delhi), PhD (public health), AIIMS New Delhi                                              | [36, 37] |
| Known initiatives | ICMR-IRIS research-impact scale, conflict-of-interest declarations for expert reviewers, National One Health Mission (ICMR as implementing agency) | [38, 52] |

## 2. Methodology and important caveats

- **Court records:** full-text searches on Indian Kanoon for "Dr. Rajiv Bahl", "Dr Rajiv Bahl", "Rajiv Bahl" + ICMR / "Director General" / "Indian Council of Medical Research" / "Department of Health Research" / contempt, plus the misspelling "Rajiv Bhal". Each relevant order was downloaded and read in full [74].
- **News:** Google News index queries for "Rajiv Bahl" with court, complaint, allegation, controversy, contempt, probe, scam, legal, notice and criticism, plus the Hindi spelling of his name. Further web searches covered Lokpal/CVC/corruption, RTI/CIC, whistleblower complaints, recruitment irregularities, deepfake/impersonation scams, conflict of interest (WHO/Gates), the ICMR data leak, the BHU Covaxin study and the sudden-deaths study.
- **Name collision:** Indian Kanoon returns 800+ hits for "Rajiv Bahl". Most involve **other people:** a Delhi advocate named Rajiv Bahl (e.g. JVG Finance, Koshika Telecom, Moolchand Khairati Ram Trust) and private family/property litigants (e.g. *Rajiv Bahl v. Vinay Kumar Bahl*, *Rajiv Bahl & Ors v. State*, 2011). **These were excluded from Sections 4-7**, which include only records naming him with an ICMR/DHR designation. Private namesake cases are examined separately in Section 9.
- **Limits:** Indian Kanoon does not index every order (many district-court and some tribunal orders are missing). Sealed matters, internal departmental complaints, Lokpal/CVC complaints and RTI replies are usually not public. Some major Indian outlets (The Hindu, Indian Express, Times of India, Hindustan Times, Mint) block automated retrieval, so their reports were seen only through headlines in news indexes. **'Nothing found' means nothing in public sources searched, not proof that nothing exists.**
- **Fairness:** Being named as 'respondent' or 'alleged contemnor' in a service dispute is **not** evidence of wrongdoing. Outcomes are reported exactly as recorded in each order.

## 3. Findings at a glance

| Category searched                                                      | Result                                                              | Status    |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| Criminal cases / FIRs / chargesheets against him                       | None found                                                          | -         |
| Corruption, bribery, financial fraud or 'scam' allegations against him | None found                                                          | -         |
| Lokpal / CVC / CBI / ED / vigilance complaints or probes naming him    | None found in public sources                                        | -         |
| Sexual harassment / personal misconduct allegations against him        | None found                                                          | -         |
| Research misconduct / plagiarism / retractions                         | None found (full Retraction Watch database; PubPeer for 188 papers) | Section 8 |

| Category searched                                                                       | Result                                                                                                         | Status                                                                     |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Supreme Court contempt petition naming him (official capacity)                          | 1 matter (3 orders)                                                                                            | Closed 01.12.2023, compliance accepted                                     |
| High Court matters naming him as respondent                                             | 1 writ (Bir Singh, Delhi HC)                                                                                   | Withdrawn 19.11.2024                                                       |
| CAT contempt petitions / OAs naming him (official capacity)                             | 20 orders (19 matters) across Delhi, Chennai, Hyderabad, Bangalore, Jabalpur, Patna, Cuttack benches           | All CPs closed / withdrawn / dropped; 1 OA allowed against ICMR (Sreehari) |
| Adverse judicial finding on an action under his authority                               | 1: CAT Bangalore quashed suspension extensions (Sreehari)                                                      | Decided 30.10.2025                                                         |
| Official-capacity involvement (non-adverse)                                             | NGT O.A. 717/2024; Delhi HC rare-disease committee; SC stem-cell judgment follow-up; AIM letter / Bombay HC IA | NGT and Delhi HC ongoing at last record                                    |
| Public controversy involving his own action                                             | BHU Covaxin paper: letter threatening legal/administrative action (May 2024)                                   | Paper retracted Sept 2024                                                  |
| Supreme Court contempt notice to the office of DG-ICMR (public health, not service law) | Bhopal gas victims' medical care and records, W.P. 50/1998                                                     | Notice 26.09.2025; next date 14.11.2025; later outcome not found           |
| Institutional controversies during his tenure (not against him)                         | ICMR Covid-test data leak (Oct 2023, CBI); vaccine / sudden-death debate (2023-25)                             | See Section 7                                                              |
| AIIMS-era (1994-2002) and WHO-era (2003-2022) allegations / cases                       | None found (incl. ILO Administrative Tribunal, WHO oversight, research ethics)                                 | See Section 8                                                              |
| Land / property / financial scams outside ICMR                                          | None attributable to him; namesake cases ruled out or undetermined                                             | See Section 9                                                              |

## 4. Court and tribunal matters naming Dr. Bahl as a party

Unless stated otherwise, Dr. Bahl is named only by designation (DG, ICMR / Secretary, DHR) as respondent or 'alleged contemnor'. 'CP' = contempt petition; 'OA' = original application; 'CAT' = Central Administrative Tribunal.

| #  | Forum / case no.                                                          | Petitioner                                  | Allegation / subject                                                                       | Outcome (date)                                                                                                                                 | Ref       |
|----|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| 1  | Supreme Court, Contempt Pet. (C) 1186-1187/2023 in SLP (C) 1555-1556/2022 | Shivkumar Shrinarayan Prajapati             | Alleged non-compliance with SC order of 04.05.2023. Bahl named as alleged contemnor no. 1. | Notice 13.10.2023; counsel stated compliance 06.11.2023; <b>contempt closed 01.12.2023</b> : court satisfied with ICMR office order 30.11.2023 | [1, 2, 3] |
| 2  | CAT Delhi, CP 400/2022 in OA 1906/2022 (+ CP 402/2022, CP 281/2023)       | Dr Ravindra Nath & others                   | Project staff disengaged despite interim protection (EMF health-effects project)           | <b>Closed 04.07.2023</b> : project over, no contempt                                                                                           | [4]       |
| 3  | CAT Delhi, CP 677/2023 in OA 1579/2023                                    | Dr Satyendra Pandey & 8+ others             | Non-compliance re appointments                                                             | <b>Closed 24.11.2023</b> : appointments offered, grievance redressed                                                                           | [5]       |
| 4  | CAT Delhi, CP 556/2023 in OA 3788/2018                                    | R.P. Sharma (ex-Accounts Officer, 76)       | Non-compliance with direction to decide claim                                              | <b>Closed 19.01.2024</b> : speaking order 05.01.2024                                                                                           | [6]       |
| 5  | CAT Hyderabad, CP 25/2023 in OA 91/2022                                   | R.S. Venkateswara Rao & 3 (retd. NIN staff) | Non-compliance (retiral benefits)                                                          | <b>Closed 15.02.2024</b> : fully complied                                                                                                      | [7]       |
| 6  | CAT Delhi, CP 508/2023 in OA 1289/2021                                    | Indra Rani                                  | Wilful defiance; recovery from pay/pension after promotion withdrawn                       | <b>Closed 04.03.2024</b> : Rs 14,45,580 refunded; no wilful defiance. ICMR's Delhi HC writ (W.P.(C) 15034/2023) disposed 28.11.2023            | [8]       |
| 7  | CAT Delhi, CP 693/2023 in OA 3342/2016                                    | Rajinder Singh                              | Representation rejected on delay, not merits                                               | <b>Closed 05.04.2024</b> : no wilful act; liberty to challenge speaking order                                                                  | [9]       |
| 8  | CAT Chennai, CP 31/2023 in OA 871/2021                                    | Dr R. Premleela (Scientist B)               | Non-regularisation                                                                         | <b>Closed 26.06.2024</b> : supernumerary post created, regularised from 01.06.1989                                                             | [10]      |
| 9  | CAT Delhi, CP 381/2023 in OA 3658/2019                                    | Bir Singh                                   | Not re-engaged while juniors continued                                                     | <b>Closed 04.07.2024</b> : case considered                                                                                                     | [11]      |
| 10 | Delhi HC, W.P.(C) 15945/2024                                              | Bir Singh                                   | Challenge arising from the above                                                           | <b>Withdrawn 19.11.2024</b> with liberty to challenge order of 14.12.2023                                                                      | [14]      |
| 11 | CAT Chennai, CP 50/2023 in OA 917/2021                                    | Dr S.S. Dhanalakshmi (Scientist B)          | Non-compliance (regularisation)                                                            | <b>Closed 05.07.2024</b> : complied by office order 24.06.2024                                                                                 | [12]      |
| 12 | CAT Delhi, CP 821/2023 in OA 3629/2022                                    | Sunil Singh                                 | Non-compliance                                                                             | <b>Closed 18.11.2024</b> : speaking order 18.08.2023                                                                                           | [13]      |
| 13 | CAT Delhi, CP 384/2024 in OA 2692/2022                                    | Deeksha Chhabra (Research Asst.)            | Defiance of interim order 06.09.2023                                                       | <b>Withdrawn 30.11.2024</b>                                                                                                                    | [15]      |
| 14 | CAT Delhi, CP 682/2024 in OA 1942/2022                                    | Vipin Kumar (Scientist-I)                   | Defiance of order 09.05.2024                                                               | <b>Closed as not pressed 30.11.2024</b> after Delhi HC (W.P.(C) 16185/2024, 25.11.2024) sent the order back to CAT for reconsideration         | [16]      |
| 15 | CAT Jabalpur, CP 54/2023 in OA 103/2022                                   | Janki Kanojiya                              | Non-compliance (NIRTH Jabalpur)                                                            | <b>Withdrawn 06.12.2024</b> : grievance redressed                                                                                              | [17]      |
| 16 | CAT Delhi, CP 469/2024 (MACP compliance, OA 2348/2021)                    | Dharmendra Singh & 12 others (MTS)          | MACP upgrade at wrong grade pay for 14 applicants                                          | <b>Closed 29.01.2025</b> : no wilful delay                                                                                                     | [18]      |
| 17 | CAT Delhi, CP 469/2024 in OA 2163/2024                                    | Dharmendra Singh (MTS)                      | Disengaged 31.05.2024 despite interim order not to disengage; entry to building barred     | <b>Closed 18.03.2025</b> : no wilful defiance (project tenure ended); main OA listed                                                           | [19]      |
| 18 | CAT Delhi, CP 319/2025 in OA 1112/2024                                    | Lalit (NICPR Noida)                         | Non-compliance                                                                             | <b>Closed 26.05.2025</b> with liberty to revive; ICMR challenged CAT order in Delhi HC                                                         | [20]      |
| 19 | CAT Patna (Ranchi), CP 21/2023 in OA 310/2021                             | E. Swapna (NIMR field unit)                 | Non-compliance (pay fixation)                                                              | <b>Dropped 19.08.2025</b> : substantially complied                                                                                             | [21]      |

| #  | Forum / case no.                        | Petitioner                         | Allegation / subject                     | Outcome (date)                                                 | Ref  |
|----|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| 20 | CAT Bangalore, OA 170/00009/2024        | Dr U. Sreehari (Scientist D)       | Challenge to suspension extensions       | <b>OA allowed 30.10.2025:</b> extensions quashed (Section 4.1) | [22] |
| 21 | CAT Chennai, CP 128/2024 in OA 422/2020 | V. Sironmani (retd. social worker) | Non-compliance (regularisation and dues) | <b>Closed 10.04.2026:</b> regularised, Rs 66,47,401 paid       | [23] |
| 22 | CAT Cuttack, CP 40/2023 in OA 25/2020   | Satyabadi Maharana (retd. clerk)   | Deductions from gratuity (DCRG)          | <b>Dropped 09.09.2026:</b> no wilful disobedience              | [24] |

**Pattern:** all 22 entries are service-law disputes, and 20 are contempt petitions alleging that ICMR had not complied with earlier orders. The usual explanation recorded is compliance through a later 'speaking order' or payment. No order found records a finding of contempt, a fine or costs against Dr. Bahl. In some matters relief came only after the contempt petition was filed. For example, #16 records that six applicants got their MACP upgrade after contempt notices were issued.

#### 4.1 Adverse ruling: Dr U. Sreehari v. Union of India & Ors (CAT Bangalore, 30.10.2025)

**Background (admitted facts in the order):** Dr Sreehari, Scientist-D and Officer-in-Charge of the ICMR-NIMR field unit in Bengaluru, faced a 2020 sexual-harassment complaint from a project staff member (the complaint was **against Dr Sreehari, not Dr. Bahl**). A Rule 14 CCS (CCA) charge sheet followed on 30.12.2022. He had been compulsorily retired in 2021, was reinstated by CAT and then suspended the same day (23.02.2023). The suspension was extended several times. The extension of 26.12.2023 was issued by 'Director General, ICMR & Disciplinary Authority'. CAT stayed it on 09.01.2024. An order of 18.10.2024 signed 'Dr. Rajiv Bahl, Director General, ICMR & Disciplinary Authority' treated 07.11.2023 to 03.03.2024 as deemed reinstatement with full pay [22].

**Holding:** The suspension reviews and extensions were not done and communicated before each earlier period expired, as Rule 10(7) CCS (CCA) Rules requires. The extension orders of 05.07.2023, 29.08.2023, 16.10.2023 and 26.12.2023 were quashed. Dr Sreehari was to be treated as on duty from 23.05.2023 to 06.02.2024 with full pay and allowances, payable within 3 months [22].

**Assessment:** this is a **procedural** finding against ICMR's disciplinary process, including one order issued under the DG's authority as Disciplinary Authority. It does not find bad faith, corruption or personal misconduct by Dr. Bahl. No appeal by ICMR was found in the indexed records.

#### 4.2 Supreme Court contempt: Shivkumar Shrinarayan Prajapati v. Dr. Rajiv Bahl & Anr.

This was the only Supreme Court matter found with Dr. Bahl as the named party. It alleged non-compliance with an SC order of 04.05.2023 arising from SLP (C) 1555-1556/2022 (the underlying dispute is not described in the indexed orders). Notice issued 13.10.2023. On 06.11.2023, counsel for 'alleged contemnor no. 1' said the order had been complied with. On 01.12.2023 a bench of Bela M. Trivedi and Satish Chandra Sharma, JJ. found compliance through ICMR's office order of 30.11.2023 and **closed the contempt proceedings**. ICMR was represented by ASG Aishwarya Bhati [1, 2, 3].

### 4.3 Supreme Court contempt notice: Bhopal gas victims' medical care (Sept 2025)

On 26.09.2025 a bench of P.S. Narasimha and A.S. Chandurkar, JJ. issued notice on a contempt plea in *Bhopal Gas Peedith Mahila Udyog Sanghathan v. Union of India* (W.P. 50/1998). Notice went to the **Director General, ICMR**, the Secretary of the Union Health Ministry, the Madhya Pradesh Chief Secretary and the Principal Secretary of the state's Bhopal Gas Tragedy Relief & Rehabilitation Department. The plea alleges non-compliance with the Supreme Court's 2012 directions on medical care for gas victims and computerisation of their medical records. Its complaints include doctor vacancies at Bhopal Memorial Hospital & Research Centre and a records system that is 'neither patient-centric nor provides comprehensive treatment history'. It also notes that the Madhya Pradesh High Court had criticised the authorities' 'callous approach' [55, 56]. The next date was 14.11.2025.

**Assessment:** the notice is addressed to the **office** of DG-ICMR, which Dr. Bahl held at the time, together with three other senior officials. He is not named personally in the reports. Unlike the service disputes above, this concerns a long-running public-health obligation. **Its later outcome could not be found**, so it should be treated as **possibly still pending**. Check Supreme Court case status before relying on it.

## 5. Official-capacity involvement in other proceedings (non-adverse)

You asked for these to be kept because they show **involvement**. In each matter below Dr. Bahl or his office plays a role, but **no allegation is made against him**. Each entry states only what the record shows about his role.

| Matter                                                                                                                                                     | His role per the record                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | Status                               | Ref          |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|--------------|
| <b>NGT, O.A. 717/2024:</b> suo motu case on an NDTV report about cancer-causing flame-retardant chemicals (TCEP, TDCIPP, TCIPP) inside cars                | ICMR is respondent no. 3. On 23.05.2025 <b>Dr. Bahl appeared personally (by VC)</b> . He told the Tribunal ICMR can test blood/urine of exposed taxi drivers versus unexposed people but needs certified reference standards, and undertook to file timelines. NGT ordered an affidavit within 8 weeks, excused his further appearance on his assurance an expert would attend, and listed the matter for 26.09.2025. | Pending at last indexed order        | [25]         |
| <b>Delhi HC, W.P.(C) 16270/2024,</b> Kiara Rawat v. Union of India (rare-disease treatment funding under NPRD-2021)                                        | On 28.10.2025 the Court constituted a committee to oversee the rare-disease crowdfunding platform, <b>with Dr. Bahl as Chairperson</b> . Its tasks include steering CSR/PSU funds and implementing NPRD-2021, meeting monthly. On 09.01.2026, on an application citing protocol, Dr. V.K. Paul (NITI Aayog) became Chair and <b>Dr. Bahl stayed a member</b> . The Court asked the committee to act 'expeditiously'.  | Ongoing (court-supervised committee) | [26, 27, 28] |
| <b>Supreme Court, Yash Charitable Trust v. Union of India,</b> 2026 SCC OnLine SC 131 (30.01.2026): stem-cell therapy for autism                           | SC held stem-cell therapy for autism cannot be offered as routine or commercial treatment, only in approved trials. Reports say <b>Dr. Bahl, as Secretary DHR, asked the NMC to comply</b> . The NMC advisory of 25.03.2026 was issued on ICMR recommendations.                                                                                                                                                       | Judgment final; advisory issued      | [29, 30, 31] |
| <b>Awaken India Movement letter</b> (20.07.2023), filed alongside IA (St) 12276/2023 in Kiran Yadav, W.P. 6151/2021, Bombay HC (vaccine-injury litigation) | Letter addressed to Dr. Bahl asking ICMR to warn the public of alleged vaccine-linked sudden deaths. <b>It does not allege personal wrongdoing by him</b> . Whether he or ICMR is a respondent in W.P. 6151/2021 could not be confirmed. Related Bombay HC orders found (Ambar Koiri / Serum Institute, 2023) do not name him.                                                                                        | Status of Bombay HC IA not verified  | [32]         |

### Leads checked and excluded (no involvement shown):

- **Tamil Nadu medical-college excess-fee probe panel (July 2026):** a news index matched it to his name, but the article does not mention Dr. Bahl or ICMR [53].
- **Supreme Court EWS free-treatment case** (Union of India v. Moolchand Khairati Ram Trust, 2026): the 'Rajiv Bahl' in these orders is an **advocate** appearing as counsel, not the ICMR DG [54].
- **'One Health Mission work is in progress: ICMR DG's letter to MP'** (Indian Express, 10.09.2026): headline seen in the news index, but the article could not be retrieved, so its contents (including any complaint by the MP) are **unverified**. Worth checking manually.

## 6. Public controversies involving his own actions

## 6.1 BHU Covaxin study: letter warning of 'legal and administrative action' (May 2024)

**Facts.** BHU researchers (Dr Upinder Kaur, Dr Shankha Shubra Chakrabarti and others) published a one-year observational study in *Drug Safety* (Springer Nature). About one-third of 926 Covaxin recipients reported 'adverse events of special interest' [44]. In a letter dated 18 May 2024, signed by Dr. Bahl as DG, ICMR [39, 40]:

- demanded removal of the paper's acknowledgement of ICMR: "*You have acknowledged ICMR for research support without any prior approval or intimation to ICMR, which is inappropriate and unacceptable*" [39];
- called the study 'poorly designed': no unvaccinated control arm, telephonic follow-up a year later without clinical verification [40, 45];
- asked the authors to explain "*why the ICMR should not take legal and administrative action against them*" and asked the editor to retract or publish an erratum. Reports quote ICMR: "*Failure to do so may prompt ICMR to consider legal and administrative action*" [39, 41, 42].

**What followed.** The authors denied malicious intent and said the phase-IV study had ethics approval [44]. *Drug Safety* retracted the paper on 24 Sept 2024 because the editor 'no longer has confidence in the conclusions'. The authors disagreed [43, 44]. **Bharat Biotech**, ICMR's co-developer of Covaxin, filed a **Rs 5 crore defamation suit in Hyderabad** against the authors and the journal editor. About 600 scientists and citizens signed an open letter calling the suit 'harmful for science' [43, 44].

**Assessment:** this is the most significant public controversy tied to Dr. Bahl's own conduct. Critics read the warning of legal action as a chilling signal to independent vaccine-safety research, especially because ICMR co-owns Covaxin. ICMR's position was that it was wrongly credited and the method was flawed. **No legal action by ICMR or Dr. Bahl against the authors was found.** The defamation suit is Bharat Biotech's, and he is not a party to it.

## 6.2 Other public positions that drew criticism (official capacity)

- **Excess-deaths study (July 2024):** he publicly dismissed a *Science Advances* paper estimating about 1.19 million excess deaths in India in 2020. The Health Ministry called its estimates 'untenable and unacceptable' [57]. This is a policy and scientific dispute, not an allegation.
- **Indian child-growth standards (2023):** he chaired an expert meeting on India-specific growth standards. Critics warned that lower standards could understate stunting [58]. This is a policy debate, not an allegation.

# 7. Institutional controversies during his tenure (not allegations against him)

## 7.1 ICMR Covid-19 test data leak (Oct 2023)

In October 2023, a threat actor ('pwn0001') offered for sale records said to cover about 81.5 crore Indians (names, phone numbers, addresses, Aadhaar and passport details), claimed to come from ICMR's Covid-19 testing database. The leak was flagged by US firm Resecurity; CERT-In alerted ICMR [47]. The CBI took up the probe. Delhi Police arrested four men, who were later also booked for separate 'data brokering'. Police said how the data was obtained was still being probed and that the data came from 'various organisations' [46, 48]. **No public source found names Dr. Bahl as accused or blames him personally.** It is an institutional data-security failure that happened under ICMR's watch during his tenure.

## 7.2 Covid-19 vaccines and 'sudden deaths' debate (2023-2025)

ICMR-led studies (2023; and an ICMR-AIIMS study publicised July 2025) found no link between Covid-19 vaccination and unexplained sudden deaths in young adults [49, 51]. In July 2025 Karnataka CM Siddaramaiah publicly suggested hasty vaccine approval could be linked to heart-attack deaths in Hassan district, and the Centre rebutted him citing ICMR/AIIMS work [50]. Vaccine-injury groups also petitioned ICMR (Section 5) [32]. **These are policy and scientific disputes about ICMR's findings, not allegations of misconduct by Dr. Bahl.**

## 7.3 ICMR-IRIS research-metric reform

His 'Publication-Equivalent' (ICMR-IRIS) scoring system drew academic debate in IJMR letters (e.g. over citation-based distortions between disciplines). This is ordinary scholarly criticism, not an allegation [52].

#### 7.4 Pre-tenure ICMR audit finding (for context)

CAG Report 26 of 2022 found ante-dated promotions of 14 scientists at ICMR-NICED Kolkata (2009-2019), with about Rs 2.07 crore in irregular payments. The period is **before** Dr. Bahl joined ICMR as DG, and he is not implicated [59].

## 8. Full-career review (1984-2026)

You asked for his whole career, including the WHO years, to be checked. Each period was researched separately: court databases, the ILO Administrative Tribunal (which hears WHO staff disputes), Retraction Watch/Crossref, PubMed, journal correspondence, and English and Hindi news indexes.

| Period           | Role (per official profiles)                                                                                                                                                | Allegations / cases found      | Notes                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1984-1999        | MBBS, University College of Medical Sciences, Delhi (1984 batch); MD Paediatrics, University of Delhi (1993); PhD, AIIMS (1999)                                             | None                           | Pre-2003 Indian Kanoon hits for 'Rajiv Bahl' are the Delhi advocate of that name [60, 37]                                                                                                                                |
| 1994-2002        | Scientist, ICMR Advanced Centre for Diarrhoeal Disease & Nutrition Research, AIIMS New Delhi (zinc, vitamin A, breastfeeding trials with N. Bhandari, S. Taneja, M.K. Bhan) | None                           | No ethics, consent or placebo complaints found about his Delhi-slum zinc/vitamin A trials or the Haryana breastfeeding trial. The national vitamin A policy dispute of that era does not name him [65]                   |
| 2003-2012        | WHO Geneva: Medical Officer, Dept of Child & Adolescent Health and Development; in charge of newborn and child health research                                              | None                           | ILO Administrative Tribunal: 0 judgments mention 'Bahl' [61]. No WHO oversight, harassment or conflict-of-interest material names him                                                                                    |
| 2013-2022        | WHO Geneva: Head of Research, Maternal, Newborn, Child & Adolescent Health (and Ageing)                                                                                     | None                           | Trials he co-led (AFRINEST/SATT antibiotics, ACTION-I steroids, iKMC) drew <b>scientific</b> debate in journal letters on design, diagnosis and early stopping. None alleges misconduct or an ethics breach [62, 63, 64] |
| Oct 2022-present | Secretary, DHR & DG, ICMR (extended to Oct 2027)                                                                                                                            | Official-capacity matters only | See Sections 4-7                                                                                                                                                                                                         |

**Research integrity:** no retraction, expression of concern, PubPeer thread, plagiarism or misconduct finding was found on any of his papers. **Retraction Watch database** (full dataset, 72,790 records, current to 30.09.2026, via Crossref's official mirror): only two records have a 'Bahl' author. Both are other people: Rachna Bahl (UK obstetrics, BJOG, retracted 2024) and Nitin Bahl (Delhi anaesthesia, retracted 2016). **PubPeer:** 188 DOIs of his papers (identified by co-authors or WHO/AIIMS/ICMR affiliation) were checked; there were no comment threads. **Corrections:** his record shows only routine errata. The most substantive is a 2025 corrigendum to a 2015 Acta Paediatrica breastfeeding meta-analysis, correcting one mortality figure in the abstract from 4.8 to 2.84. Other errata are in the Lancet (2014, 2019, 2023), BMJ (2018), Sci Rep (2022) and JAMA Netw Open (2021). **Limitation:** 188 of his 250+ papers were covered; consortium-authored and early papers may be missed. [72, 73]

**Limitations for older periods:** 1990s Indian newspaper archives are mostly offline. Internal AIIMS/ICMR inquiries and WHO oversight investigations are not published. ILO Administrative Tribunal judgments are anonymised and rarely name supervisors, so a nil result there cannot rule out a staff dispute in which he was a supervisor. Swiss court records cannot be searched online by party name.

## 9. Personal / non-ICMR matters: land, property, fraud

Court databases and news (English and Hindi) were searched for any Rajiv Bahl linked to land, property, plots, the DDA, fraud, cheating (IPC 420), FIRs, cheque bounce, partition or arrest. Company-director records were also checked. Every private case found involving a 'Rajiv Bahl' was examined for identifying details. **No case is attributed to Dr. Bahl without concrete identifying evidence.**

| Case                                                                              | Subject                                                                                                                                                                                                            | Is it the ICMR DG?                 | Evidence                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Ref  |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| Delhi HC, FAO 327/2007, <i>Rajiv Bahl &amp; Ors v. State</i> (decided 25.01.2011) | Probate of the estate of Smt. Ram Piari (14 Kautalya Marg, Chanakyapuri). Appellants lost; the codicil they relied on was held 'fabricated' (civil probate finding, not a criminal finding against a named person) | <b>Ruled out</b> (high confidence) | The judgment says appellants' father Dinesh Bahl 'married a German lady and settled in America since 1972' and his family was not expected to settle in India. Dr. Bahl studied and worked in Delhi without a break from the 1980s to 2002 | [66] |

| Case                                                                                 | Subject                                                                                                                                                               | Is it the ICMR DG?                                | Evidence                                                                                                                                                                                                      | Ref          |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|
| Delhi HC, W.P.(C) 1110/2020, <i>Rajiv Bahl &amp; Anr v. GNCTD</i> (order 20.07.2022) | Challenge to a Delhi government demolition on 31.12.2019 of 12 bighas 3 biswas in Village Asola; sent to the Deputy Commissioner for demarcation. No fraud allegation | <b>Almost certainly not</b> (not formally proved) | Court records show a different Rajiv Bahl, a businessman who co-founded Fun Foods (sold to Dr. Oetker, 2008) with his wife Vibha Bahl, living at Asola Homes, Chhattarpur. Dr. Bahl was at WHO Geneva in 2019 | [67, 68, 69] |
| Delhi HC, CS(OS) 116/2026, <i>Rajiv Bahl v. Vinay Kumar Bahl &amp; Ors</i>           | Civil suit, subject not stated in orders; defendants seek rejection of plaint; next date 05.11.2026                                                                   | <b>Undetermined</b>                               | Orders are procedural only, with no addresses or professions. Rajiv Bahl is the <b>plaintiff</b> ; no allegation against him                                                                                  | [70]         |
| Delhi HC W.P.(C) 6423/2026; CIC appeal 2019-20                                       | Leave entitlement of a Department of Agriculture employee; RTI appeal                                                                                                 | <b>No</b>                                         | A different person (agriculture ministry employee)                                                                                                                                                            | [71]         |
| Various Delhi HC / SC matters                                                        | Rajiv Bahl appearing as <b>advocate</b> (JVG Finance, Koshika Telecom, Moolchand Khairati Ram Trust, etc.)                                                            | <b>No</b>                                         | A practising Delhi advocate                                                                                                                                                                                   | [54]         |

**Result: no land scam, property fraud, financial fraud, FIR, Economic Offences Wing case, DDA dispute, cheque-bounce case or arrest can be tied to Dr. Rajiv Bahl.** No company directorship was found for him; the only 'Rajiv Bahl' director record (DIN 00074263) belongs to the Fun Foods founder. Other namesakes found in news (a US emergency physician, an author, a cybersecurity executive, a private-equity professional) are different people. **Limits:** his official profiles do not publish his parentage or address, and the Delhi HC case-status portal (party addresses) needs a captcha. Certified copies of the pleadings in CS(OS) 116/2026 would settle that case. Immovable-property returns of Secretaries were not found online.

## 10. Searched with no result found

| Search area                                                                    | Result                                                                                     |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Criminal cases, FIRs, arrests, chargesheets                                    | None found                                                                                 |
| Corruption, bribery, disproportionate assets, Lokpal / CVC / CBI / ED          | None found                                                                                 |
| Financial fraud or 'scam' (procurement, recruitment, grants) attributed to him | None found                                                                                 |
| ICMR recruitment irregularities linked to him                                  | None found                                                                                 |
| Sexual harassment / POSH complaints against him                                | None found (the only POSH-related matter concerns a different ICMR scientist; Section 4.1) |
| Research misconduct, plagiarism, data fabrication, retractions                 | None found; only routine errata (Section 8)                                                |
| Conflict-of-interest allegations (WHO / Gates Foundation / industry)           | None found; his own stated COI policy is reported [38]                                     |
| Whistleblower complaints against him                                           | None found                                                                                 |
| RTI / CIC decisions naming him adversely                                       | None found                                                                                 |
| Challenges to his appointment or extension                                     | None found (appointment and extension both ACC-approved)                                   |
| Deepfake / impersonation scams using his identity                              | None found specific to him                                                                 |
| Land / property / financial fraud outside ICMR                                 | None attributable (Section 9)                                                              |
| WHO staff tribunal (ILOAT) judgments, WHO oversight / harassment reports       | None found (Section 8)                                                                     |
| Parliamentary questions naming him on irregularities                           | None found (eparlib portal blocked to automated access)                                    |
| Social media / petition-site allegations (X, Reddit, Change.org)               | None found (weakly indexed)                                                                |

**Suggested next steps for deeper verification** (sources outside open-web reach):

- e-Courts services (district/sessions courts) and the CAT online case-status system, by respondent name, for matters Indian Kanoon does not index.
- Delhi High Court and Supreme Court case-status searches by party name, for pending matters with no reported order yet.

- RTI applications to ICMR/DHR and the CVC for complaints received against the DG (outcomes of vigilance complaints are not published).
- Lok Sabha / Rajya Sabha question archives for parliamentary questions on ICMR governance, the data leak and the BHU matter.
- Manual review of The Hindu / Indian Express / TOI archives (blocked to automated retrieval), including the 10.09.2026 Indian Express item in Section 5.
- Supreme Court case status for W.P. 50/1998 (Bhopal gas contempt, Section 4.3) to confirm the outcome after 14.11.2025.
- Certified copies of the memo of parties in Delhi HC CS(OS) 116/2026 to settle the one undetermined namesake case (Section 9).

## 11. Disclaimer

This report compiles publicly available court orders and published reporting as of 01 October 2026. It does not allege wrongdoing by any person. Where allegations or criticisms appear, they are attributed to their sources. Court outcomes are summarised from the cited orders, and readers should consult the full orders for exact language. Absence of a record means none was found in the sources searched, not that none exists. This is not legal advice.

## 12. References and evidence links

All court orders are linked to their full text on Indian Kanoon, which reproduces the digitally signed orders. Retrieved 01.10.2026.

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